

SECTION 1

Policies and Principles governing admission to first degree programmes in State Universities and Higher Educational Institutes under the University Grants Commission

1.1 Admissions Policy for State Universities and Higher Educational Institutes

Admissions policy differs between the subject streams.

For students seeking admission to Arts courses mentioned in 1 to 10 of the Section 2.1 (1) of this handbook, All Island Merit is the main criterion used for selection. The district basis is not used for selection of students in this category. Therefore, all students compete on an equal basis for placements for those courses of study.

The total number to be selected for a course of study is based on a national policy. The decision is that the total number of students admitted from a given district for a particular course of study will not be below the total number admitted to that course of study from that district in the academic years 1993/1994 or 2002/2003, whichever is greater.

However there is one exception to All Island Merit selection criterion for selection of students to Arts courses.

The exception is, for selection of students to the following categories of Arts courses.

1. Music
2. Dance
3. Drama & Theatre
4. Visual Arts
5. Visual & Technological Arts
6. Art & Design

Selection for these courses is based on the district quota system which is explained below.

Also selection to all other streams, namely Commerce, Biological Science, Physical Science, Engineering Technology, Biosystems Technology and courses of study listed in Section 2.2.8 of this handbook for which students from different subject streams are eligible is based on the following criteria.

1. Up to 40% of the available places of a particular course of study is selected on the order of Z-scores ranked on All Island Merit.
2. Of the remaining 60%, up to 55% is selected on the district quota system. The district quota system is that, for a given district, in addition to the number selected under the All Island Merit (40%), additional seats are made available up to the remaining 55%. Accordingly, up to 55% of the available places in each course of study will be allocated to the 25 administrative districts in proportion to the total population of each district; that is on the ratio of the population of the district concerned to the total population of the country.
3. In addition, there are 16 districts, recognized and classified as educationally disadvantaged districts. The remaining 5% of the total available seats are given to the students of these districts. This again is allocated on the ratio of the population of each such district to the

total population of the 16 districts recognized as disadvantaged districts. The 5% is for all 16 districts and not for one district.

The 16 districts categorized as ‘educationally disadvantaged’ are,

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|-----------------|------------------|-----------------|
| 1. Nuwara Eliya | 7. Vavuniya | 13. Polonnaruwa |
| 2. Hambantota | 8. Trincomalee | 14. Badulla |
| 3. Jaffna | 9. Batticaloa | 15. Monaragala |
| 4. Kilinochchi | 10. Ampara | 16. Ratnapura |
| 5. Mannar | 11. Puttalam | |
| 6. Mullaitivu | 12. Anuradhapura | |

However, in selecting students for a given course of study, it will be ensured that the quota allocated to any district (i.e. the total of 55% and 5%) will not be below the quota in the academic year 1993/1994 or 2002/2003, whichever is greater.

It should be noted that the actual numbers selected could vary from the proposed figures by universities for each academic year, because of the practical problems encountered in allocating students to universities and other unavoidable factors. The approximate distribution of the numbers among different universities is given in Annex (b) of this handbook.

A limited number of students will also be admitted on special grounds as specified in Section 6 of this handbook, subject to the conditions set out therein.

1.2 Minimum requirements for university admission

Candidates who are pronounced eligible for university admission by the Commissioner General of Examinations should have obtained;

- (a) At least ‘S’ grades in all three approved subjects in one sitting, within a maximum of three attempts.
- (b) A minimum mark of 30% for the Common General Paper

- **Candidates who have not obtained 30% or above for the common general paper are not eligible for registration for the courses of study of the universities for which they have been selected based on the Z Score in the current academic year.**
- **If such a candidate has obtained a minimum of 30% for the common general paper in a previous attempt within three attempts allowed for university admission, the previous achievement can be considered.**
- **Candidates who have not obtained a minimum of 30% shall re-sit and obtain a minimum of 30% for the common general paper in a next available year within three attempts allowed for university admission, to be eligible to get registered for the courses of study of the universities for which the candidates have already been selected based on Z Score, in a future academic year.**

1.3 Z score obtained by the students at the G.C.E. (Advanced Level) Examination

Z score is calculated by the Department of Examinations of the Ministry of Education, Higher Education and Vocational Education and given to the UGC. This is a statistical calculation.

The calculation is based on three factors.

- i. 'Raw marks' of students for the given subject for the given year
- ii. Mean of the performance of that subject for the given year
- iii. Standard deviation of that subject for the given year

Therefore, the Z score changes with the educational achievements of the students and the total number of students offered a particular subject in the given year.

1.4 'Cut-off' marks required for admission to different courses of study at different Universities

Cut-off marks are calculated by the University Grants Commission. 'Cut-off' marks for a given course of study will depend on the factors such as how well the candidates have performed at the G.C.E. (Advanced Level) Examination in a given year, the demand for a particular course of study and the university and the number of seats available for the course of study.

Accordingly, 'Cut-off' marks may vary from year to year depending on factors such as performance of students who have applied for that particular course of study for that year, total number of places offered by universities for that particular course of study, the population of each district etc.

Sometimes, some students may not apply for university admission expecting to sit for the advanced level examination again. Also some students may apply for university admission but will not get registered for the course of study for which they have been selected because of change of mind.

Therefore, when applying for university admission, students are strongly advised to apply for a maximum number of eligible courses of study with their preferences irrespective of their Z score and the previous years' cut-off marks.

1.5 Criteria for determination of the district of a candidate for university admission

In order to decide the district of a candidate for university admission, the candidate must provide evidence of enrolment in schools for the period of last three years in his/her application form for university admission. For this purpose, the Head of the school in which the candidate is currently studying should certify the accuracy of the information provided by the school candidate in his/her application form on the basis of school records and for private candidates, a Justice of Peace/ Commissioner for Oaths should certify the accuracy of the information provided by the candidate in his/ her application form on the basis of the School Leaving Certificate.

The three year period is calculated backwards from the last date of the month, which is the month, immediately preceding the month in which the candidate sat the advanced level examination to qualify for university admission. For example, if the advanced level examination is held in December the three year is calculated backwards from 30th November of the same year.

Accordingly, the district of the school of which the candidate has studied at least one year or more during the three year period considered, will be considered as the district of the candidate for university admission.

If the candidate has enrolled in more than one school during the said three-years period, then, the district of the school of which the candidate has studied most number of days is considered as the district of that candidate for the purpose of university admission. However, that duration

compulsorily should be at least one year or more. For example, a candidate has studied in a school located in a district for one year and three months and the remaining one year and nine months in a school located in another district, then the district of the school in which the candidate has studied for one year and nine months will be the district for the purpose of university admission.

However, let us assume, if a candidate has studied in a school located in one district for eleven months and in two schools located in another district for nine months and ten months respectively. Then the second district will be considered as the district of the candidate for the purpose of university admission as the total period studied in that district (one year and seven months) is greater than the period studied in the first district (eleven months) and also the total period studied in the second district is greater than one year.

If the schooling period of the candidate is less than one year from any of the districts or candidate has not enrolled in any school for advanced level during the three year period considered, the district where the permanent place of residence of the candidate is located is the district considered for university admission. For the purpose of confirming the permanent place of residence of the candidate, following two documents should be submitted along with the application.

These two documents are,

- i. Original of the School Leaving Certificate or Original of the Pupil's Record Sheet.
- ii. Original of the Grama Niladhari Certificate (DS4 Certificate)

Note :

For private candidates, it is compulsory to submit the original School Leaving Certificate along with his/ her application for university admission.

1.6 Admission criteria for State Universities and Higher Educational Institutes established under the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended)

1. All students are provided an equal opportunity to enter state higher education.
2. To be fair to all, opportunity to enter into a free state sponsored course of study is given only once.
3. This is because, withdrawal from the registration of the course of study the student got selected or non-reporting after getting registered to a degree programme will cause loss of opportunity for university admission of another student in the same year. Also, by requesting to withdraw the registration and get registered to another course of study based on the results of a subsequent year, the student is trying to deprive the opportunity of another student who sat the examination in that subsequent year.
4. The opportunity will be given for university admission, based on the results of one of the three attempts allowed to sit for the G.C.E. (Advanced Level) examination for the purpose of university admission. Accordingly, when applying for registration, the student is allowed to apply on the results of the same examination based on which the applications for university admission are called.

5. **Once the candidate, upon receiving the letter of selection from the UGC, having made the payment of Rs. 50/= as the registration fee in credit of the UGC, to the bank or online and registers online via the official website of the UGC for the selected course of study of the University/ Higher Educational Institute to which he/she has been assigned, on or before the last date given for registration, he/she is deemed as a registered student at a University/ Higher Educational Institute, established under the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended) as mentioned in Section 1.6 (8) below.**
6. **After making the payment, the date on which the online registration to the selected course of study of the university has been completed via the official website of the University Grants Commission will be considered as the date of registration.**

Accordingly, after making the due payment in credit of the UGC to the bank or online, on or before the last date given by the UGC for registration to the selected course of study of the university, if the candidate fails to complete the registration online as stated in Section 1.6 (5) above, that will not be accepted as a valid registration.

7. **Also, if the payment is made to the bank, candidate should upload and send a scanned copy of the Paying in Voucher to UGC when getting registered online, in order to verify the payment.**
8. **The list of the all Universities and Higher Educational Institutes to which the selection and assignment of students is done by the UGC, covered under the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended) is given below :-**

- i. University of Colombo
- ii. University of Peradeniya
- iii. University of Sri Jayewardenepura
- iv. University of Kelaniya
- v. University of Moratuwa
- vi. University of Jaffna
- vii. University of Ruhuna
- viii. Eastern University, Sri Lanka
- ix. South Eastern University of Sri Lanka
- x. Rajarata University of Sri Lanka
- xi. Sabaragamuwa University of Sri Lanka
- xii. Wayamba University of Sri Lanka
- xiii. Uva Wellassa University of Sri Lanka
- xiv. University of the Visual & Performing Arts
- xv. Gampaha Wickramarachchi University of Indigenous Medicine, Sri Lanka
- xvi. University of Vavuniya, Sri Lanka
- xvii. Sripalee Campus, University of Colombo
- xviii. Trincomalee Campus, Eastern University, Sri Lanka
- xix. University of Colombo School of Computing
- xx. Swamy Vipulananda Institute of Aesthetic Studies, Eastern University, Sri Lanka

9. **The Open University of Sri Lanka (OUSL) which is also established under the above Universities Act offers courses of study using distance-learning methodologies. Information regarding admission requirements of the courses of study offered by the OUSL should be obtained from the Registrar, the Open University of Sri Lanka, Nawala, Nugegoda.**

10. Admission of students to courses offered by the following institutions is made by the respective Universities/ Institutes under the guidance of the UGC. Those seeking admission to courses offered by them should apply to the institution concerned when applications are invited.
 - i. Institute of Human Resource Advancement (IHRA), University of Colombo
 - ii. Institute of Technology, University of Moratuwa
11. This handbook describes the selection procedure for undergraduate courses in the 16 Universities, 02 Campuses and the 02 Institutes specified in Section 1.6 (8) above. The rules and regulations laid down herein are subject to revisions in terms of any decisions made by the Government/ University Grants Commission.

1.7 Ineligibility for admission to a State University or a Higher Educational Institute established under the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended)

The following categories of students do not qualify for seeking admission as internal students to a State University or a Higher Educational Institute under the UGC.

1. Students who sat the G.C.E. (Advanced Level) Examination on more than three (03) occasions.

Students need not sit the examination consecutively, but once the three attempts are completed, the student becomes ineligible to apply on the results of the subsequent attempts or on the results of the previous attempts.
2. Students who were/are registered as internal students to follow a course of study in a State University/ Higher Educational Institute established under the Universities Act No.16 of 1978 (as amended) [List of all the Universities and Higher Educational Institutes covered under this section is mentioned in Section 1.6 (8), and 1.6 (10)].
3. Students who were/are registered under free education as internal students to follow a first degree course in a State University/Institute established under any other Act of Parliament in Sri Lanka other than the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended). Which are,
 - i. Bhiksu University of Sri Lanka
 - ii. Buddhist & Pali University of Sri Lanka
 - iii. General Sir John Kotelawala Defence University (As enlisted Officer Cadets)
 - iv. University of Vocational Technology
 - v. Ocean University of Sri Lanka (Students who got registered in or after 2017)
4. Students who were/are registered in a College of Education as internal students to follow a course of study.
5. Students who were/are registered under free education as internal students to follow a diploma programme of three (03) year duration in a University College under the University of Vocational Technology.
6. Students who were/are registered as full time students to follow a course of study of three (03) years duration or more in an under mentioned institute subject to the provisions made in the paragraphs named “**Important**” below;

- a. Higher National Diploma (HND) at an institution which comes under the Sri Lanka Institute of Advanced Technological Education (SLIATE)
- b. National Diploma in Engineering Sciences (NDES) at Institute of Engineering Technology (IET) of the National Apprentice and Industrial Training Authority (NAITA)

Important:

However, a student who is registered as a full time student to follow a course of study of a three (03) years duration or more to obtain a Higher National Diploma (HND) at an institution which comes under the Sri Lanka Institute of Advanced Technological Education (SLIATE) and or National Diploma in Engineering Sciences (NDES) at Institute of Engineering Technology (IET) of the National Apprentice and Industrial Training Authority (NAITA) is given the opportunity to withdraw the registration within 60 days from the last date given for registration by the relevant Institute and apply for university admission to follow a course of study in a University or a Higher Educational Institute established under the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended) on the basis of the results of a G.C.E. (Advanced Level) Examination held in a later year.

Please note that if the student has not withdrawn the registration from the above mentioned institutions within the 60 days from the last date given for registration for a course of study mentioned in Section 1.7 (6) above, he/she will not be eligible to apply for university admission to follow a course of study in a University or Higher Educational Institute established under the Universities Act No. 16 of 1978 (as amended) on the basis of the results of a G.C.E. (Advanced Level) Examination held in a later year, since he/she comes under Section 1.7(6) above.

However, a student who is admitted **to fill a vacancy** of a Higher National Diploma (HND) at an institution which comes under the Sri Lanka Institute of Advanced Technological Education (SLIATE) or National Diploma in Engineering Sciences (NDES) at Institute of Engineering Technology (IET) of the National Apprentice and Industrial Training Authority (NAITA), mentioned in section 1.7 (6) above will not be given the concession mentioned above to withdraw their registration within the 60 days period and to apply for university admission again.

7. Students who have accepted a foreign scholarship channelled through the Ministry of Education, Higher Education and Vocational Education to study courses at the first-degree level.
8. A student who has already obtained a first degree or relevant qualification from authorities specified in paragraphs 2,3,4,5,6 and 7 of 1.7 above.
9. A student who has made a false declaration and/or produced forged documents for application and/ or registration for university admission in the current academic year or in a previous academic year.

Note:

- (i) **If the information provided by the candidate along with the application for university admission or at the registration found to be false or inaccurate prior to his/ her admission to the University/ Higher Educational Institute, actions will be taken to cancel the selections and the application for university admission submitted by the candidate for that particular academic year and he/ she will not be allowed to apply for university admissions in any of the future academic years.**

(ii) **Moreover, if the information provided by the candidate along with the application for university admission or at the registration found to be false or inaccurate after his/ her admission to the University/ Higher Educational Institute, actions will be taken to dismiss the student from the University/ Higher Educational Institute.**

1.8 Steps taken to reduce the delay in admission of students to the universities

1. Unless there are reasons beyond our control (e.g: Court cases), in future, UGC will call for applications for university admission as soon as possible.
2. **Therefore, it has been made compulsory to apply for university admission online.** This will help to reduce the time lost for processing paper applications, which enables UGC to release cut off marks early.
3. Clear guidance for online submission of applications is given in the Section 5 of this handbook.
4. If you do not have facilities to apply for university admission online or not confident to use the on-line system, Regional and Study Centers of the Open University of Sri Lanka (OUSL R & SC) or Internet Technology Distance Learning Hub (ITDLH) under Ministry of Education, Higher Education and Vocational Education closer to your residence mentioned at the end of Section 5 of this handbook will help you for the online application process **free of charge**.
5. Once cut off marks are released, all selected students must use the online registration system to register for the selected course of study of the University or the Higher Educational Institute.

Please note that this is also a mandatory requirement. Safety and security of the online application and online registration systems are guaranteed.

6. Getting the students registered online for the selected course of study of the university as mentioned in Section 1.6 (5) above is one of the steps introduced to reduce delays in the process of university admission.
7. Registration of students to courses of study of the Universities or Higher Educational Institutes online through the UGC website will reduce the registration delays that may occur at individual university level due to multitude of reasons which may be beyond their control.